The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP

Iran threatened to completely close the Strait of Hormuz if **Donald Trump** carried through on a threat to “obliterate” the country’s power plants. Late on Saturday Mr Trump gave Iran a 48-hour ultimatum to fully open the vital shipping route. On Sunday America’s president spoke with Sir Keir Starmer, Britain’s prime minister, about the need to reopen the strait, although there were no details of a joint plan.

Stocks tumbled across Asia. In early trading Japan’s Topix index fell by 3.1%; South Korea’s Kospi by 4.7%. Both countries are heavily exposed to rising energy costs. The price of Brent crude rose to $114 a barrel before falling slightly. Fatih Birol, the head of the International Energy Agency, said the war had prompted “two oil crises and one gas crash put all together”.

Iran threatened to destroy energy infrastructure in the Middle East and continued to attack the region. Saudi Arabia said it had shot down several Iranian drones. On Sunday at least seven people were injured in an Iranian missile attack on Tel Aviv; 180 were hurt in separate strikes on southern Israel on Saturday. Meanwhile more Israeli missiles hit **Tehran**, Iran’s capital.

The Israel Defence Forces said its campaign against Hizbullah, the Iran-backed militia in **Lebanon**, had “only just begun”. Earlier Lebanon’s president warned that Israel’s destruction of an important bridge in the south of his country was a “prelude to a ground invasion”. Israel said it had struck the crossing to prevent Hizbullah from getting arms and fighters into the area.

The Socialists and their allies mostly triumphed in the big cities in **France’s** mayoral elections. The party held on to power in Paris, where Emmanuel Grégoire won easily, and thwarted populists from the left and right in Marseille and Lille. In Lyon the Socialist candidate won after allying with the hard-left France Unbowed party. Hard-right and populist candidates made gains elsewhere, including in Nice.

In **Slovenia**, the parliamentary election appeared to be a dead heat between the populist Slovenian Democratic Party and the liberal Freedom Movement, headed by the prime minister, Robert Golob. Mr Golob claimed victory despite both parties having secured roughly 28% of the vote, with 99% of ballots counted. Either side will probably find forming the necessary coalition government tortuous.

Ukrainian authorities reported that six people had been killed in **Russian** drone attacks throughout the country. More were injured, including children. The assault came as American and Ukrainian negotiators met for the latest round of talks to try to end the four-year war. The Americans want to set up another trilateral meeting with Russia.

Figure of the day: $4bn, the value of venture-capital deals sealed in Africa in 2025, nearly quadruple the amount in 2020. We examine why the future of Africa will be shaped by investment rather than aid.

Photograph: AFP

Russian setbacks in Ukraine

While all eyes are on the war against Iran, something significant appears to be happening in Ukraine. Russia has begun its spring offensive, carrying out large-scale attacks. But in the five days to Saturday, Russia reportedly sustained 7,850 casualties, suffering the highest losses on two of those days since the invasion in 2022. Russian attacks have become increasingly vulnerable to reorganised Ukrainian drone units. They allow Ukraine to inflict casualties on Russian forces without risking too much of its own scarce manpower.

Meanwhile, Ukraine is striking targets deep inside Russia. Since February, at least 110 missions have been carried out. On March 17th, one adviser to the Kremlin, Sergei Shoigu, warned that “no Russian region can feel safe”; even the Urals, where much of the war economy is based, is in “the immediate danger zone”. However, despite a meeting in Miami over the weekend between American and Ukrainian negotiating teams, the prospect of Russia entering into serious talks seems as remote as ever.

Photograph: AP

Infrastructure week in the Iran War

The fourth week of the American-Israeli war against Iran began with attacks on infrastructure, with the threat of more to come. On Saturday Donald Trump threatened to strike Iran's energy plants within 48 hours if its regime does not "fully open" the Strait of Hormuz, gateway to 20% of the world's oil supplies, to shipping.

This came after an exchange of missile hits and air-strikes between Israel and Iran which targeted crucial infrastructure in both countries. Shrapnel from an Iranian missile fell on Israel's main oil refinery in Haifa, causing fires. Iran also scored direct missile hits on the southern Israeli towns of Dimona and Arad, injuring more than 160 civilians. Israel's nuclear enrichment facility is nearby. Iran claimed to be retaliating to an Israeli air-strike on its Natanz reactor, and Israel had also hit one of Iran's largest gas-fields. The war has already caused a spike in global energy prices; much worse may be in store.

Photograph: Getty Images

Pakistan’s dire straits

Pakistan Day is supposed to be the appointed time when the country’s powerful military forces get to flex their muscles. The annual celebrations, to commemorate the adoption of its Islamic constitution in 1956, typically involve goose-stepping, missiles, tanks and an air show. This year’s events have been cancelled, though, as the country reels from surging oil and gas prices. A simple flag-hoisting will have to do.

Pakistan is among the countries most exposed to Iran’s closure of the Strait of Hormuz. With almost 90% of its oil and gas coming from the Middle East, large debts and scant foreign-exchange reserves, it is in a tight spot. Already, the government has closed schools and hiked petrol prices. To make matters worse Pakistan’s war with the Taliban in neighbouring Afghanistan is at risk of escalating after an airstrike hit a hospital in Kabul on March 16th. The country’s military leaders find themselves between Iran and a hard place.

Violent events*, Jan 1st 2026-Mar 13th 2026

Perpetrator: ○ Pakistani military ● Afghan military ○ TPP

*Battles, explosions/remote violence or violence against civilians Source: ACLED

300 km

Photograph: Samuel Corum/Sipa USA

SCOTUS takes up postal balloting

On Monday, with the midterm elections less than eight months away, America's Supreme Court tackles a question that could change how votes are counted.

The dispute in *Watson v Republican National Committee* concerns Mississippi's law that allows mail-in ballots to be counted if postmarked by election day and received up to five business days later. Republicans challenge this grace period as a violation of 19th-century federal statutes that set "Tuesday next after the first Monday of November" as America's uniform election day.

Mississippi counters that elections are complete once "voters have marked and submitted their ballots". The RNC says "chaos and suspicions of impropriety" would ensue without a firm deadline. Mississippi warns that scrapping the leeway would "doom" the laws of nearly 30 states that count some ballots after election day, potentially disenfranchising many thousands of voters—particularly the elderly and disabled, as well as Democrats, who tend to rely more on postal voting.

Photograph: Getty Images

Is private credit cracking?

Worries about private credit are intensifying. For months, funds that invest in unlisted debt have seen their clients attempting to withdraw money, despite the assets the funds hold being illiquid. They typically cope with this by imposing limits on how much cash investors can pull out. But the news in February that a retail fund run by Blue Owl had failed to honour its withdrawal terms has sparked panic. Investors are rushing to extract their capital even from funds run by giants like BlackRock.

It is unclear whether Blue Owl's fund was simply mismanaged or failed because of a structural flaw. In private, its peers point to the rush of money that flowed into it and similar funds in the months leading up to the jitters. They muse that the need to invest this quickly led to lax underwriting standards for loans that are likely to turn sour. Given the speed with which investors have funnelled capital into the wider private-credit market in recent years, that is a disturbing thought.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily Quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Which album by Joni Mitchell, released in 1971, is often rated as one of the greatest of all time?

The more the state “plans” the more difficult planning becomes for the individual.

Friedrich Hayek